

Western capercaillie

Tetrao urogallus

The capercaillie is the world's largest grouse. It survives mostly in old pine forests with an abundance of shoots and berries beneath the trees and in clearings close by. In summer, the birds look for food on the ground, but in winter, they often feed on shoots high up in trees. Male capercaillies gather and display in a lek to attract and impress the females, which then move away to nest.

Increasing deer, declining capercaillies

Capercaillie populations have declined almost everywhere, disappearing entirely from some forests. Climate change may play a role, but deterioration in capercaillie habitat is sometimes related to an increase in the deer population.

Capercaillies need a healthy growth of low shrubs, which provide essential cover and a rich diet. With too many deer browsing on these shrubs, capercaillies face a food shortage. High fences pose another problem. Because these birds can only fly low, many collide with fences intended to keep out deer and are killed.



short, rounded wings

- ↔ 24–34 in (60–85 cm)
- ⚖ 4–9 lb (1.8–4.1 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Seeds, berries, shoots
- 🏠 



N., W., and S. Europe,
W. to C. Asia

▷ VYING FOR ATTENTION

A male capercaillie displays to impress females, while making croaking, gurgling, and cork-popping sounds.



Common adder

Vipera berus

The common adder is the most widely distributed member of the viper family and is the only venomous snake in northwest Europe. Its front upper fangs, folded back along the jaws, tilt down in an instant to strike immobilizing venom into prey. The adder's diet includes frogs, lizards, birds, voles, and other small mammals. It is not an aggressive snake, but it will bite a human if stepped on or handled. The bite is painful, and may cause swelling, but is rarely fatal.

Winter retreat

In their southern ranges, common adders stay above the ground and active all year. Further north, however, they spend the long cold winters together in large groups in a cave, burrow, or similar hideaway. They emerge from late spring to summer to mate. Females breed only once every two or three years and may mate with several males. The female gives birth to 10–15 live young who have to fend for themselves within hours of birth.

▷ HOSTILE DANCE

Male adders wrestle with each other to establish dominance. They raise up the front part of their body and attempt to push their opponent to the ground.

- ↔ 24–35 in (60–90 cm)
- ⚖ Up to 6 oz (180 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Small mammals, reptiles
- 🏠 



Europe, C. to E. Asia



flat head

distinctive dark zigzag line running down back